

Navigating Life After Treatment

A practical guide to remission and re-integration

After receiving the all clear, do not be surprised if you find yourself somewhat confused. You were expecting bells and whistles, maybe a shooting star. Instead you got all your friends and family almighty happy for you, but you feel happy but flat. You should be happier, but you feel exhausted, thoughtful, quietly happy, but unsure if this is really the end.

Here it comes: you are not the only one, and this feeling is entirely normal. There are a series of challenges ahead to be faced with patience, determination, and a splurge of courage. Depending on what you have had to face, the cancer journey may have:

- Got rid of a few friends and created unexpected new ones
- Introduced you to the heavy reality of cancer-related fatigue
- Impacted your relationships with your partner, children, and loved ones
- Forced you to face a journey back to work which, in all aspects, must be gradual
- Required you to confront your finances and manage ongoing treatment side effects

The list is long. We will make a steady start.

1. Fear of Recurrence: Scanxiety and Hyper-Vigilance

When active treatment ends, the safety net of frequent hospital visits and daily medical contact disappears. You are left with your own thoughts, and every subtle ache can start to feel like a threat.

The Reality: Fear of recurrence is one of the most common and persistent effects of finishing cancer treatment. A 2023 UK study followed 229 people who had been treated for sarcoma and found their fear of the cancer returning was markedly higher, on average, than fear of recurrence levels seen across other cancer types. Around seven in ten of them said they wanted more support with this fear than they were currently getting.

The Challenge: Every upcoming scan or check-up can bring on scanxiety, and your mind jumps to the worst case before you can stop it, making it hard to plan ahead with any confidence.

The Steady Start: Name the fear when it appears rather than fighting it. Learn to hold an anxious thought without acting on every one of them, and build a plan for the days around scans and check-ups rather than facing them unprepared.

2. Cancer-Related Fatigue

Cancer-related fatigue is not ordinary tiredness. It is physical and mental exhaustion that a good night's sleep does not fix, and it can be one of the hardest things to explain to people who expect you to be back to normal.

The Reality: Cancer Research UK estimates that around 30 in every 100 people experience fatigue that can last for years after treatment ends.

The Challenge: Friends and colleagues often expect your old energy back now that treatment is over. Pushing through it rather than pacing yourself tends to lead straight to a crash.

The Steady Start: Treat your energy like a bank account with a fixed daily balance, not an unlimited supply. Spend it deliberately, prioritise what actually matters, and build rest in before exhaustion forces it on you.

3. Psychosocial Impact and Relationship Shifts

Cancer reshapes your social world, often in ways nobody warns you about.

The Reality: Macmillan's own guidance is direct about this: some friendships fall away, not always out of unkindness but because people do not know what to say, especially once everyone assumes you are fine. Others surprise you, showing up in ways you never expected. Family and partner relationships often shift too.

The Challenge: Partners may carry their own quiet burnout, children may carry unspoken anxiety, and you may find yourself constantly reassuring other people about your own health.

The Steady Start: Accept that cancer acts as a filter on your relationships. Let go of resentment toward the people who could not show up, cherish the ones who did, and set clear boundaries about what you are willing to discuss.

4. Career Re-Evaluation: To Return or Not

Before rushing back to your old routine, it is worth looking honestly at your finances and at whether your old path still fits who you are now.

The Reality: Around 890,000 people of working age are living with cancer in the UK, and Macmillan's research finds that nearly 60 percent of people who were working at diagnosis have had to give up work or change their role because of it. Separately, Office for National Statistics research on health

conditions requiring hospitalisation found that cancer accounts for close to three billion pounds a year in lost earnings in England, and over eighteen thousand fewer people in employment as a direct result.

The Challenge: You may feel pressure to jump straight back into full-time work, even though your priorities, stress tolerance, and physical capacity have genuinely changed.

The Steady Start: Do a sober financial review before making big career decisions. Check your sick pay entitlements, know your baseline living costs, and weigh whether returning to your old role, changing your hours, or pivoting entirely fits your life now. Neither should be decided in a rush.

5. Workplace Re-Integration and Capacity Realities

Returning to work rarely means simply picking up where you left off.

The Reality: Macmillan's research also found that over 80 percent of people who were working at diagnosis still felt it was important to return to work. Wanting to go back does not mean it will feel simple. Fatigue, and the cognitive changes that often travel with it, sometimes called brain fog, can make even familiar work feel unfamiliar for a while.

The Challenge: The question that comes up most is honest and uncomfortable: can I still do this job at my current capability? Expecting yourself to operate at full capacity from day one leads straight to overwhelm.

The Steady Start: Work with your employer on a genuinely phased return. Be transparent about what support you need, normalise taking breaks, and recognise that adapting how you work is common sense, not a failure.

A Final Word

None of this is a checklist to complete alone. I am Marcelo Marques, a two-time cancer survivor treated at The Royal Marsden Cancer Centre under Professor Martin Gore, a holder of a Diploma in Transformational Coaching from the Animas Centre for Coaching, and a holder of the Cancer Survivorship Certificate (Silver level) from MD Anderson Cancer Center. I wrote this guide because I lived every one of these five chapters myself, twice.

If any of this resonates, I offer a free 30 minute discovery call, no obligation, no pressure either way.

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